

59.1 The Empire, Divided

Henry, hoping to get the entire territory of the old empire back under his thumb, spent most of the summer of 1311 laying siege to the rebellious city of Brescia. In September, the city finally surrendered. Genoa, ambivalent about emperors, agreed without much conviction to give Henry a twenty-year oath of loyalty; Pisa, historically pro-emperor, declared itself on his side, offered him six hundred bowmen, and provided him with transport down the coast to Rome on thirty Pisan ships.

Henry decided that this was victory enough for the moment, and headed for his coronation. But the Romans, not happy to see him, shut the gates against him. Stalled on the outside, Henry was finally forced to go to the church of St. John Lateran, beyond the city's limits, for his coronation. As soon as the ceremony was finished—June 29, 1312—he started back up north. He intended to bring Florence, the center of the resistance, to its knees.[14]

He laid siege to Florence in September. But the city held out with ease, and by January Henry had decided to take a temporary break from the attack. He went instead to Pisa, where he allowed his army to rest, and sent to Germany for reinforcements.

The new regiments did not arrive until July, by which point Henry had grown more and more severely ill with a malarial fever that had tormented him since the previous fall. He died on August 24, 1313, having spent all but a few months of his reign outside of Germany.[15]